

HIGH SCHOOL BASKETBALL

Fast Break

A quick look at action on the courts



CHRIS STEPHENS / PLAIN DEALER

Clearview's Taz Sutton drives past Midview's Brett Boron.

THE WEEK IN REVIEW

MONDAY

Holy Name and Villa Angela-St. Joseph were impressive, but Manchester, Hudson, East Tech and Lorain Catholic learned they still have a ways to go when it comes to competing with the upper echelon of Ohio girls basketball.

While competing in the prestigious All-Ohio Prep Shootout in Pickerington, which featured 16 teams that were ranked in the Associated Press statewide poll, Holy Name and VASJ each won two games, but the others suffered decisive losses. All was not lost, however. The experience was worth the two-hour drive.

TUESDAY

Mayfield's first boys victory of the season came in style. Chad Raymond hit a shot at the buzzer to give the Wildcats a 64-62 victory over Riverside and a 1-9 record.

Clearview's girls had little time to celebrate being the state's No. 1-ranked Division III team as the Clippers dropped a 68-54 non-conference game to visiting Margaretta. The Clippers entered the matchup thinking they were the No. 5-ranked team, and Margaretta was No. 6.

The new state rankings came out in The Plain Dealer the next morning, and the Clippers (11-1) found themselves atop the poll, despite their setback. Margaretta still held sixth place, although the Bears were tied with Lutheran West for the spot.

Clippers coach Jim Horvath said: "Let's just say, it's great news, but it arrived at the wrong time. I don't know if we would have played any better knowing this before we took the floor, but we might have been able to enjoy it more before our defeat."

WEDNESDAY

The Wellington girls saved their best for last in a 46-42 Lorain County Conference victory at Firelands. Wellington trailed, 42-35, with 2:47 left, but finished the game with an 11-0 run. The Ducks (5-2 in the LCC) were led by Karla Bartish's 17 points and Eva Die-drick's 11.

Glenview served notice by defeating state-ranked Shaw, 76-70, in a boys nonleague game at Shaw. James O'Neal Johnson's Tar-blooders finished with four players in double figures.

LAST NIGHT

Heading into a home game against Twinsburg, Nordonia's Larry Farmer needed 16 points to become the school's first player to score 1,000.

No problem. The senior scored 24 points to lead the Knights to a 73-57 win.

THE WEEK AHEAD

TODAY

St. Ignatius begins a grinding four-game trip as the Wildcats travel to Bedford. It's a matchup of The Plain Dealer's seventh- (Bedford) and eighth-ranked teams.

St. Ignatius has a date at Mentor on Jan. 30 and travels to St. Edward on Feb. 5. The Wildcats have an afternoon game the next day against top-ranked Shaker Heights at Brush. St. Ignatius returns home Feb. 12 to face talent-laden Villa Angela-St. Joseph.

Benedictine's boys will find out what many of Shaker Heights' opponents have learned this season: The Raiders are deep, and they come at you in waves.

Shaker, ranked No. 1 in The Plain Dealer poll, and Benedictine, ranked No. 11, meet tonight at Brush, with a junior-varsity start time of 6.

Can Benedictine weather the storm? At least the Bengals' starters got some rest last night, pushing out to a 62-39 third-quarter lead in a 73-50 win over Walsh. Senior Michael Woods led Benedictine with 21 points.

Free Throws

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Bulldogs press the issue against Demons

By DICK ZUNT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTEROLMSTED FALLS
WESTLAKE61
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It was a case of just too much pressure by Olmsted Falls.

The host Bulldogs pressured the ball from one end of the gym to the other last night en route to breaking a first-place conference tie with Westlake.

BOYS

The final score was 61-41, in favor of Olmsted Falls, which leads the Southwestern Conference with a 6-1 record.

Olmsted Falls, which tied Rocky River for the SWC championship last season, pressured the Demons into 15 first-half turnovers en route to lifting their overall record to 8-2.

Westlake slipped to 6-6, 5-2 in

the conference.

"We're not big, but I thought that we played hard," said Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue. "We do have quickness, and if we do not pressure the ball, they [Demons] would throw the ball inside to their big men [6-7 Pete Hartenburg and 6-3 Zarrett Fiebig]."

Westlake coach Art Daniels said: "We have a young team, and we hope to learn from tonight and grow."

Olmsted Falls took a 7-0 lead in the first 1:28. Westlake called a 20-second timeout, but when play resumed, the Bulldogs' pressure kept taking its toll.

Westlake closed to within 15-8

after a field goal by Hartenburg with 1:43 left in the first quarter.

But junior guard Larry Mucha drove for a layup with 38 seconds left in the quarter and followed that with a 3-pointer to give Olmsted Falls a 20-8 lead entering the second quarter.

The Bulldogs kept up their pressure and pushed to a 31-11 lead after a jump shot by junior forward Jake Schneider with 4:11 left in the second quarter.

Sophomore forward Marcus Robinson, who played two quarters of the junior-varsity game and two quarters of the varsity game, scored three field goals in the last 2:41 of the second quarter to help Westlake shave its deficit to 33-23 at halftime.

The third quarter was somewhat of a repeat of the first quar-

ter as Olmsted Falls held the Demons to eight points in eight minutes.

Olmsted Falls led, 46-31, after three quarters and boosted its lead to 50-31 at 7:04 of the fourth quarter, when Mucha sank four straight free throws after two technicals were called on Westlake. The second one came after the ball was kicked in response to the first technical.

Mucha led all scorers with a season-high 18 points. He sank two 3-pointers in the first quarter and made 6 of 6 free throws in the fourth quarter.

"Westlake is a good team, and we had to play hard," said Mucha, an 80 percent free-throw shooter. "Our defense is based on pressure on the ball, and we played pretty good defense tonight."

Two other Bulldogs finished in double figures. Sophomore Mike Gansey had 15 points and junior Manzie Williams had 11.

Robinson led Westlake with 10 points.

"About three or four games ago Robinson moved up," Daniels said. "He played a nice game."

"This is the first time our team has been involved in a first-place game like this, the first game of the second round [of conference play]. They wanted it so bad that their frustrations boiled over [with the technicals]. We lost our composure a couple of times."

Said Donahue: Overall, I was pleased with our effort. We handle the ball well and try to minimize our turnovers and take advantage of those of the other team."

Middies storm back

Rally keeps Midview unbeaten

By JACK McDERMOTT
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

With 5:40 remaining in last night's Lorain County Conference boys basketball showdown between undefeated Midview and once-beaten Clearview, the visiting Clippers led,

53-44, after a 5-footer by 6-3 sophomore Miles Davis.

Unfortunately for Clearview, time didn't stand still, and neither did the Middies, who came roaring back with 13 straight points to take a 57-53 lead with 18.3 seconds remaining.

A 3-pointer at the buzzer by Clearview's Jack Gute wasn't enough as the Middies held on for a 57-56 victory.

Midview is 10-0, 6-0 in the LCC. Clearview dropped to 8-2 and out of a first-place tie in the LCC with a 5-1 mark.

MIDVIEW
CLEARVIEW57
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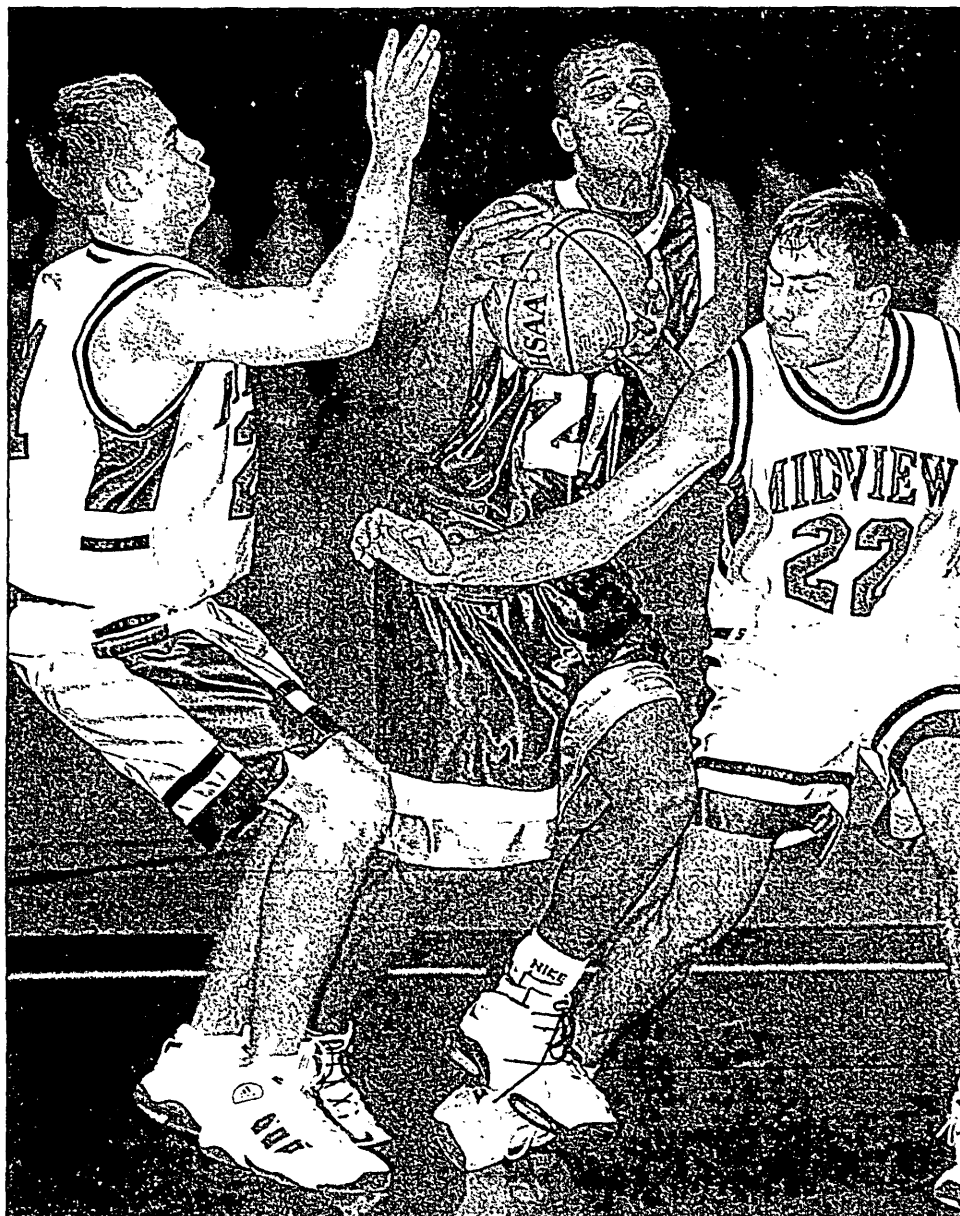
"This is a very disappointing evening for us," said Clearview coach John Szalay. "This was a game that we should have won but didn't. We weren't the team that scrapped back, trying to make it interesting. We were a team with a nine-point lead with just under six minutes remaining, that hit the wall, both fatigue- and foul-wise, and let them take it away from us."

"I give Midview all the credit in the world. They're an outstanding team, and that's why they're undefeated."

The turning point for the Middies came with 3:21 remaining, when senior Kyle Crawford was fouled by Clearview junior Kenny Gilbert. Crawford sank two free throws, giving the Middies their second lead of the night, 54-53.

Crawford then scored on a fast-break, off a pass from junior Ben Elwell, to give Midview a 56-53 lead with 2:14 remaining. With 18 seconds left, Gilbert picked up his fifth foul, and Gerber responded by making the first of two free throws, setting the stage for Gute's too-little-too-late trey as the horn sounded.

"We got up by nine, then we tried to run the clock a little bit," Szalay said. "But then they turned up the pressure, and things started to come apart on us. All of a sudden, it was one shot and out for us, and they started to connect. We fouled them, but they never seemed to get into a situation where they had to foul us, or



CHRIS STEPHENS / PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPHER

Clearview's Kenny Gilbert [21] feels the heat from Brett Boron (left) and Doug Gerber during Midview's 57-56 win.

at least if they didn't, they weren't being called.

"We're a good foul-shooting team, but we only got to the line three times in the second half [making one], while they shot 11 [making eight]. But, hey, this season is far from over, and we'll go back out and keep plugging along to get ready for the next time we meet them, Feb. 23, at our place."

Said Midview coach Troy DiFranco: "We were down by nine, we called a timeout and told the kids to suck it up and go back out

and apply full-court pressure. We were impatient in the first half, and we told the kids we needed to get the ball inside more in the second half. It was a great defensive effort on our part in the fourth quarter that pulled it out."

Doug Gerber led the Middies with 23 points, shooting 6-of-8 in the first half. Elwell was next with eight points, six in the fourth quarter.

The Clippers were led by Gilbert and senior Taz Sutton with 13 points each, and Davis scored 10. Gilbert entered the game av-

eraging 20.3 points.

"We had Kyle guarding Gilbert tonight, and he held him to just two free throws in the first half," DiFranco said.

"Kyle is the best man-to-man player around, and he just went out and hounded Gilbert the whole way. And, Gerber was just fantastic in the first half, he caught fire and kept us in the ballgame. This was a big game for us, and we all wanted to win real bad. And, before we took the floor tonight, I saw a fire in their eyes that I haven't seen before."

Barberton hangs on to defeat Stow, 56-45

HANGS ON FROM 1-D

Senior David Hasson and junior Larry Stang led Stow with nine points apiece.

The Bulldogs were 19-of-60 from the floor to 22-of-46 for the Magics, who climbed to 9-1 overall. Stow was 3-of-17 on 3-pointers. Stow's leading scorers, Tim LaFleur and Chris Hydeck, were held to a combined 14 points. LaFleur had scored 94 points in his last three games.

Barberton, coming off a gut-wrenching 110-99 double-overtime loss to Massillon on Tuesday, took the lead for good on a basket by Tarver off an offensive rebound with a little more than five minutes left in the first half. While the lead grew to 15 with 2:04 left in the third, Stow fought back as Hasson scored five points and Stang banked in a 3-pointer in the final seconds to get the Bulldogs to 33-26.

The Magics took command as Tarver scored twice on inside moves, and Cline scored five of

'We didn't play real well, but neither did they. I'm just happy we won.'

DARREN TARVER Barberton player

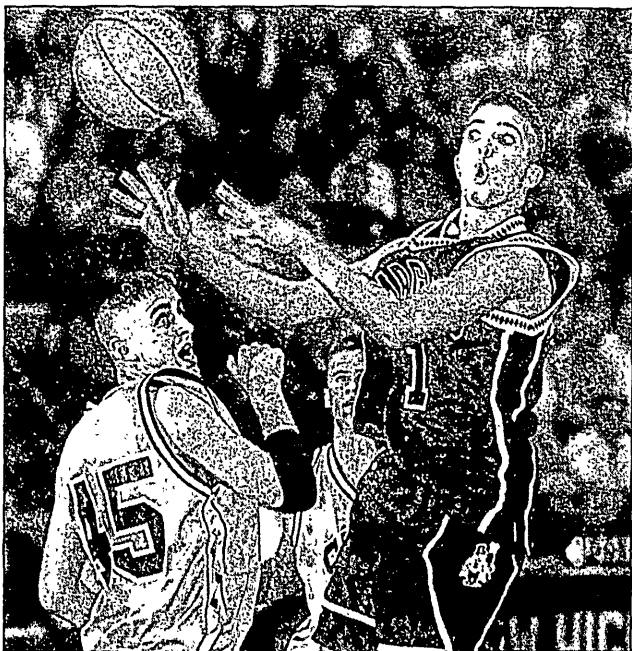
his 12 points in the first two minutes of the fourth quarter.

"We didn't play real well, but neither did they," Tarver said. "I'm just happy we won."

Rector was concerned that his team would still be suffering the aftereffects of the loss to Massillon.

"It was a big concern," Rector said. "I never feel losses are good for you, but our kids battled the whole game against Massillon. We were tired, we got home late and it's exam week. Then we only had two days to get ready for Stow."

As it turned out, two days were enough.



BILL KENNEDY / PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPHER

Barberton's Chad Hazard makes a no-look pass over Stow's Chris Young during the Magics' 56-45 victory.

Keystone rolls as Rader's radar on

By BOB MIGRA
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Cris Rader was having one of those nights.

Rader's first shot came off an offensive rebound early in the first quarter. Falling backward,

he launched a 10-foot shot toward the basket. The ball banked softly off the

backboard and through the net as Rader slid backward on the seat of his pants.

It was a sign of things to come. Rader did not miss much, scoring 19 points to lead Keystone to a 57-39 victory over host Avon in a Lorain County Conference boys basketball game. The Wildcats improved to 6-3, 3-2 in the LCC.

"During the pregame warmup, I wasn't making much of anything," Rader said. "But during the game, I don't know what happened. There were a few shots I threw up there that shouldn't have gone in."

KEYSTONE
AVON57
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Avon coach Dave Kudela said his team did not have an answer for Rader's hot shooting.

"I was somewhat surprised by the way they shot the ball," Kudela said. "Rader played very well all night."

Rader was not the only Wildcat to shoot well. Keystone made 22 of 42 shots in the game. Dustin Banks scored 13 points, and Nick Moore scored 10.

"I thought Keystone played pretty well," Kudela said. "Whether it was our defensive breakdowns, or it was just Keystone's night, I don't know. Regardless, we still have to score more points. We're not going to win many ballgames scoring 39 points."

Avon fell to 1-8, 0-5 in the LCC.

Despite Rader's eight-point first quarter, neither team took command. Erich DeChant scored three of Avon's first four field goals as the Eagles trailed, 10-8. DeChant led Avon with 14 points.

A 3-point goal by Moore and a jump shot by Shawn Fallon gave Keystone a 15-8 lead, but Avon came back with a jump shot and a three-point play by Chris Cornett to trail, 15-13.

A layup by Moore and a jump shot by Rader gave the Wildcats a 19-15 lead after one quarter.

Keystone extended its lead in the second quarter. Banks hit a jump shot, then a 3-point goal for a 26-17 lead.

Avon again whittled the lead on a slam dunk by Ryan Krystowski and layups by DeChant and Cornett and trailed, 28-23.

The Wildcats did not pull away until a six-point flurry in the final 8.2 seconds of the third quarter.

It started with Fallon making the first of two foul shots. After Jason Maurer rebounded Fallon's second shot, Todd Hodkey scored on a driving layup and was fouled. Hodkey made the ensuing foul shot for a three-point play and a 45-35 lead with a half-second left.

Keystone got another opportunity after Avon's inbound pass sailed out of bounds. Hodkey lobbed the ball in front of the basket for Banks, who redirected the ball toward the basket. The shot bounced in as the buzzer sounded for a 47-35 Keystone lead.

In the fourth quarter, with coach Greg Morgan imploring his team to take the open shot, Keystone instead chose to weave time off the clock, holding Avon to a four-point quarter.

"If they're being more conservative than out-of-control, I'm happy," Morgan said. "We didn't score a lot of points, but we got the win, and that's the goal."